

added services aggregator, formally released *LILA Hindi Prabodh* for mobile phones, in collaboration with C-DAC (Centre for Development of Advanced Computing), Pune. LILA stands for “Learning of Indian Languages through Artificial Intelligence,” being developed by C-DAC for

computers, and is now available for mobile phones. LILA Hindi Prabodh for mobile phones is from the LILA series being developed by the Applied Artificial Intelligence Group at C-DAC.

It uses MMC multimedia cards—the latest Hindi Prabodh courseware is embedded in the card, and a multimedia interface has been incorporated.

“The courseware is an adaptation of the LILA series applications available on CD and the Web. The object was to address the target group which consisted of government employees, language enthusiasts, tourists from outside India, and the common masses interested in learning Hindi,” says Amit Jhaveri, COO, Enable M.

Multimedia output for learning has been used in LILA Hindi Prabodh for Mobile, where the user can read and listen to Devanagari letters as used in Hindi. The translation of a Hindi sentence into English and sentence structure patterns can be learnt. The courseware also carries exercises and practice sets. In addition, video clips of narrative sections of lessons in Hindi and a Hindi-English Dictionary are embedded in the MMC.

How It Works

Most of the rural population can afford a basic mobile phone. “TeachMe Akshara is developed on the innovative VectorDraw engine that works even with basic level monotonic handsets with Java support. It was important for us to take this design consideration because our aim was to make this application usable by any mobile phone owner,” says Varghese. The application is 16 KB for colour phones and 32 KB for black and white phones.

The easy-to-use program focuses on enabling learning of the Hindi and Malayalam alphabets. It teaches the user to read and write the letters, and how they are pronounced.

If one wants to learn how a letter is written in Hindi, by selecting the Write option, one can view an animation of a pencil drawing the letter on a notepad playing on the screen.

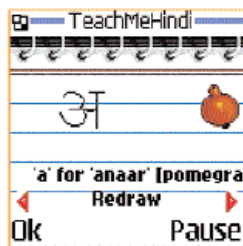
Pronunciation is learnt when the user selects a letter: on clicking it, a graphic to depict an object (such as a pomegranate) whose name begins with that letter comes up. Thus the user can relate the graphic with the letter. As the animation of the letter is played on the screen, the pronunciation of that letter is played over the phone’s speakers.

Thus, one learns a language by first learning to read the letters, then how they are written by

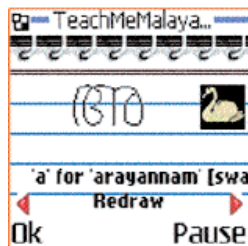
watching the animation, and finally the pronunciation of the letter.

LILA Hindi Prabodh uses artificial intelligence to educate users about the Hindi language. Unfortunately, the MMC can, of course, only be used with mobile phones supporting the card format.

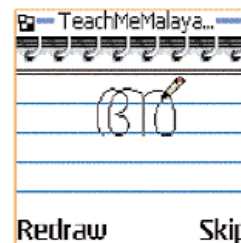
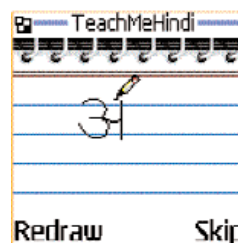
“About 30 odd lessons with ten exercises for self-assessment are included in the courseware. Animation of letters and words being written in Hindi are played on the screen along with their pronunciation. Audio elements are added to learn the pronunciation and videos of the narrative aspects of lessons are added to give the course an enjoyable learning experience,” says Jhaveri.



TeachMe Akshara relates letters to sounds using image associations



Within a few years, we can expect the mobile content market to boom, and we will see more applications that can exploit the use of mobile phones as educational tools



...and also shows you how to write the letter in question

The translation of a Hindi sentence can be seen in English: the sentence is written with English letters, and the sounds are spoken in Hindi. The user can also view video clips of lessons in the narrative sections.

The Formal Launch

TeachMe Akshara wasn’t launched formally, so not many know about it.

“Since our product was made public and was not formally launched, we have received very few commendations. The feedback from the people cannot be assessed since the product has not been able to fully reach the general public. Talks are on with a couple of big corporations to look to it as a potential Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) tool, and we believe it will soon be available to the general public. Very soon, it would be available for Reliance customers through the R-World menu,” informs Varghese.

Concluding Notes

According to the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India, more than 149.5 million people in India owned a mobile phone, and 6.4 million subscribers were added in December 2006. With such mobile penetration, the choice of a proper path for implementation of this technology has to be made. The flexibility of personal learning via mobile phones breaks the barriers of location and time.

Within a few years, we can expect the mobile content market to boom, and we will see more applications that can exploit the use of mobile phones as educational tools. The mobile content and services market in India is in a nascent stage. For now, kudos to the efforts of Gopalakrishnan and Varghese. ■

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